Writing and structuring reports

The role of the Research Report

The main role of the research report is to communicate the findings of the research project. The project should answer the questions raised in the statement of objectives of the study. The researcher should be clearly aware of the purpose of the research when preparing the report. A research project can being out a lot of information but much of this information may not be relevant to the problem initially defined. Only information that is likely to be useful to the decision maker in decision making should be included in the report.

Research Report Criteria

Writing Criteria

A report should satisfy the following criteria to improve its chances of communicating effectively with the reader:

(a) Completeness

A report should provide all the information that readers need in a language they understand. This means that the writer should continually ask himself whether all the issues in the research objectives have been addressed.

b) Accuracy

The preceding steps in the research process provide the basic input for the report. This means that the data generated at the data collection and analysis steps should be accurate in order for the report to be accurate.

c) Clarity

Writing clearly is not easy. Clarity is achieved by clear logical thinking and precision of expression. The way the report is organized may contribute to clarity or affect it negatively. Some principles of writing clearly are:

(i) Use short and simple sentences.

(ii) Use simple words which the reader is familiar with.

(iii) Ensure that words and phrases express exactly what the writer means to say.

(iv) Avoid grammatical errors.

(v) Use uniform style and format. It may help to write a first draft and then have another person review it before preparing the final report.

d) Conciseness

The criteria of completeness should not be complemented by conciseness. The writer should be concise in his writing and selective with regard to what to include in the report. The report

should be brief and to the point – this means that the report should not include everything that has been found but only what is relevant to the study.

Report Format

The organization of the report influences its ability to meet all the criteria of report writing. There is no format that is appropriate for all reports. A report should be use a format that best fits the needs of its readers. The following format may be used for most types of reports. It should be seen as flexible and open to changes and adjustments depending with needs of the reader.

Title page or cover sheet

Abstract.

Acknowledgements

Contents listing.

List of figures and tables

Project body

Background of study

Problem statement

Statement of objectives

Hypothesis/research questions

Significance/justification

Scope and limitations

Theoretical framework

Literature review

7. Research methodology

(a) Research design

(b) Data collection method

(c) Sampling

(d) Fieldwork

(e) Analysis and interpretation.

9. Findings of the study

10. Summary and conclusions

11. Recommendations

12. Appendix

(a) Copies of data collection instruments

(b) Details of sample size determination.

(c) Table not included in the findings

(d) Bibliography.

Let us briefly discuss each of these terms

1. Title page

The title page should indicate the subject of the report, the name of the organization for whom the report is prepared, the name of organization or person who prepared it and the date the report is prepared.

2. Table of Contents

As a rough guide, any report of several sections that totals more than 6 to 10 pages should have a table of contents. This shows in order of appearance the topics and subtopics of the report with page references. It also includes table and charts and pages where they may be found.

3. Summary/Abstract

Some authors consider the summary to be the most important part of the report. This is mainly because most executives read only the summary or they use it to guide them on what areas of the report to give more attention. It should contain the necessary background information as well as the important findings and conclusions. Two pages are generally sufficient for executive summaries. Write this section after the rest of the report is finished.

4. Problem Statement

It contains the need for the research project. The problem is usually represented by research question (s). it is followed by a more detailed set of objectives.

5. Statement of Objectives

This states the objectives of the study and should clearly indicate the purpose of the study and what the report tries to answer.

6. literature review

Background material may be of two types. It may be preliminary results of

exploration from an experience survey, focus group, or another source.

Alternatively, it could be secondary data from the literature review.

7. Research Methodology

This section describes the research procedures or methods used. It should indicate the research design, sampling procedures, data collection and data analysis procedures used.

This section provides information on the manner in which the findings reported were gathered, analyzed and interpreted.

9. Findings of the study

In this section which makes the bulk of the report, the results of the study are presented. The specific objectives of the study should be kept in mind and the results should be presented in a logical manner. Only information that contributes to answering the questions posed in the study objectives should be reported. Tables, charts and figures should be presented in a logical manner to facilitate flow of thought and appreciation.

Summary and Conclusions

The summary is a brief statement of the essential findings. Sectional summaries may be used if there are many specific findings. They may be combined into an overall summary. In simple, descriptive research, a summary may complete the report, because conclusion and recommendations may not be required.

Findings state facts, conclusions represent inferences drawn from the findings. Conclusions should be drawn with reference to the objectives of the study. The researcher should show the step by step development of conclusions and state them with some detail.

Conclusions may be presented in a tabular form for easy reading and reference. If for some reason the study does not obtain adequate data on which to make conclusions, this should be acknowledged.

11 Recommendations

There are usually a few ideas about corrective actions. In academic research, the recommendations are often further study suggestions that broaden or test understanding of the subject area. In applied research the recommendations will usually be for managerial action rather than research action. The writer may offer several alternatives with justifications.

Appendix

The appendix provides a place for material that does not fit in the other parts of the research report. This may be because its too detailed, technical or specialized, or is not absolutely necessary for the text.

The appendix normally contains details on sample design and sample size determination, an exhibit copies of the data collection instrument; maps used to draw up the sample; detailed statistical tables and figures. The appendix helps those interested in the technical details to find them easily.